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Lack of Rain Threatens Power Shortage Here

While the records of precipitation on the Jordan River watershed for September during the past 30 years have almost always shown heavy rains, this year's rainfall has been very slight.

The past month, in fact, has been about the driest on record.

This serious shortage, coupled with an extremely heavy increase in the demand for electric power by essential war industries, has seriously depleted the water stored in the reservoirs of the B.C. Electric Railway Company's main generating plant at Jordan River, and this water is likely to become exhausted unless heavy rain is experienced within the next few weeks, according to a statement issued today by A. T. Goward, vice-president.

CAUSING CONCERN

Mr. Goward said: "While I do not wish to create any unnecessary alarm over what may quite possibly develop into a difficult situation with regard to the supply of electricity in the near future, I feel it is my duty to issue a warning and to point out that due to an exceptionally dry season and heavy demand for power by essential war industries, the water situation at our Jordan River power plant is causing us some concern. Unless heavy rainfall is experienced within the next week or two, it will be necessary to curtail, in some way, the use of electric power, particularly in homes, offices, stores, theatres and the less essential industries, and even in essential industries where curtailment can be effected without serious detriment to the work involved, in order to ensure an adequate supply of power for the more vital war industries operating in and about Victoria.

USE EMERGENCY PLANTS

"I also wish to make it clear that early last spring, anticipating the possibility of a long dry season, we took every precaution to conserve the supply of water at Jordan River by operating the Brentwood Bay steam plant and the hydro-electric plant at Goldstream continuously since early spring, in addition to purchasing power from other local generating sources, thus relieving the demand upon the Jordan River plant as much as possible.

"However, in spite of these precautions, the extremely scanty rainfall and the greatly increased demand for power has reduced the water stored in the Jordan River reservoirs to a very low level.

NEW UNIT DELAYED

"We had hoped to have had the large additional steam-turbo-generating unit now being installed at Brentwood Bay in readiness for operation long before this.

"This unit was ordered in March, 1941, considerably more than two years ago and, under ordinary circumstances, would have been delivered, installed and in service almost a year ago.

"However, serious delays and difficulties inseparable from wartime conditions intervened, and the complete unit, which has at last arrived, is now being installed as rapidly as possible. Unfortunately, it will be impossible to have this ready for service before towards the end of the year — too late for the present emergency.

"In these serious circumstances I appeal to all citizens to curtail as much as possible the use of electrical energy in every way they can during these few weeks of emergency."

Five parking and one speeding case in city police court today resulted in a total of $22.50 in fines being paid.

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